

# A Reader's Guide to the AISH Manual

*A plain-language, campaign-focused guide to the AISH Manual (DIA Program Policy), last updated July 2, 2026 — what it is, and where the provisions that matter most to our community are found*

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The AISH Manual is 212 pages long. It is the policy manual caseworkers and adjudicators use to run AISH and ADAP day to day. No one should have to read all of it, and this guide does not ask you to. Instead, it points you to the sections that decide the things people fight hardest over — who qualifies, who cannot appeal, and how a life gets sorted into one program or the other — and puts each in plain language, using the manual's own words. Read it alongside the manual itself, which is reproduced with this document.

## How to use this guide

The manual is organized into named policy sections, each with an **Authority**, an **Intent**, and a **Policy** heading. Below, each entry names the section and tells you, in plain terms, what it says and why it matters. Quotations are taken directly from the manual. Because this is the manual that governs both AISH and ADAP, watch the labels closely — many rules apply to one program and not the other, and the manual is careful to say which. So are we.

## The section that seals the most important door: Medical Review Panel

This is the section to read first. The manual explains that the Director's power to decide whether someone has a severe disability that permanently prevents employment is delegated to a **Disability Income Assistance Adjudicator** and to the **Medical Review Panel (MRP)**. The adjudicator can approve AISH directly for high-priority cases, or refer harder ones up to the MRP.

Then comes the line that matters most. In the manual's own words: **“A determination by the MRP that an applicant has/does not have a severe disability that permanently prevents employment is final and is not subject to appeal.”** But the very next line draws a distinction that is easy to miss and important to hold: **“A decision by the adjudicator not to refer an application to the Medical Review Panel is subject to appeal to the Medical Appeal Panel.”**

## What that distinction means in practice

Two different decisions, two different fates. If the **MRP** looks at your case and says no, that medical decision is final — there is no appeal of it. But if the **adjudicator** never sends your file to the MRP in the first place, *that* decision — the refusal to refer — can be appealed to the Medical Appeal Panel. So the sealed door is specifically the MRP's final medical determination. The adjudicator's decision not to refer is not sealed. Knowing which decision you are facing tells you whether a door is open. This is the manual confirming, in black and white, where the appeal bar falls.

## Who qualifies, and the word doing the heavy lifting: “permanent”

The **Severe Disability Definition** section is where eligibility is won or lost. The manual defines a severe disability as a substantial impairment of mental or physical functioning “**that is permanent or likely to continue for at least two years ... and for which all relevant treatment that could lessen the impairment has been completed and where no improvement is expected.**” That last clause is the test a doctor's report has to speak to: treatment tried, no improvement expected.

The section also draws the AISH/ADAP line in the manual's own terms. For **AISH**, the question is whether the severe disability *permanently prevents* employment. For **ADAP**, whether it *substantially impedes* employment “continuously or episodically.” The manual adds a caution people should know: if a severe disability does not prevent (AISH) or impede (ADAP) employment to that standard, a person may not meet the medical criteria for either program.

### Why this belongs on the record

The whole two-program split turns on the difference between *prevents* and *impedes* — two words, in one definition, sorting tens of thousands of people into different benefit levels. The documented effect is that a single medical determination, made without considering any factor other than the disability's impact on employment, decides which side of the line a person lands on. The manual states the standard plainly; the consequences of the standard are what the campaign documents.

## Where the rest of the campaign-critical provisions live

- **Eligibility, and Maintaining Eligibility:** who qualifies, the duty to report changes in circumstances, and the situations that can interrupt benefits — including moves to or from institutions, facilities, or hospitals.
- **Re-assessment:** the manual confirms a reassessment of eligibility can occur, and that ADAP clients whose medical condition or capacity to work changes may apply for AISH — the reassessment path that remains open with no deadline.
- **Cohabiting Partners:** a partner's income and assets are included in determining a client's benefits — the household rule that can reduce what a person receives.
- **Income and Assets:** long tables setting out what income is fully exempt, partially exempt, or counted, and which assets are protected. This is the source to check when a member asks whether a specific payment or asset affects their benefits — always by program.
- **Sponsored Immigrants:** the manual states AISH and ADAP may recover from a sponsor the full cost of benefits issued — a recovery power worth knowing about.

### One line worth noting for the historical record

Among the income-exemption tables, the manual lists a **Sterilization Settlement** as a payment the Minister has designated exempt — compensation for sterilization. It is a small administrative line in a benefits manual. It is also a quiet acknowledgement, inside today's disability-policy machinery, of a documented harm done to disabled Albertans in the past. Noted here without further claim, for the record.

### **The bottom line**

You do not need all 212 pages. You need to know that the appeal bar falls on the MRP's final medical decision (not on the adjudicator's refusal to refer), that eligibility turns on “permanent” and on the gap between “prevents” and “impedes,” and that the income, asset, and household rules live in the tables. This guide points you to each. The full manual is reproduced with it so you can read any section in the source.

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*Source: Government of Alberta, AISH Manual (DIA Program Policy), last updated July 2, 2026. Section names and all quoted passages are drawn from that manual. This guide is a plain-language reader's companion, not the official manual and not legal advice. Where it differs from the official manual, the manual governs.*